

Parts Used Aerial parts.

Constituents The herb contains saponins (including anagalline), tannins, and cucurbitacins. The latter are cytotoxic (damaging to cells).

History & Folklore Classical Greek writers believed scarlet pimpernel helped melancholy. In her *Modern Herbal* (1931), Mrs. Grieve quotes an old saying: "No heart can think, no tongue can tell/The virtues of the pimpernel." It has been employed in European folk medicine as a treatment for gallstones, liver cirrhosis, lung problems, kidney stones, urinary infections, gout, and rheumatism. This pattern of use suggests a detoxifying action for the plant.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Little used by medical herbalists today, scarlet pimpernel has diuretic, sweat-inducing, and expectorant properties. As an expectorant, it was used to stimulate the coughing up of mucus and help recovery from colds and flu. It has been used to treat epilepsy and mental problems for 2,000 years, but there is little evidence to support its efficacy.

Caution Scarlet pimpernel is not recommended for medicinal use for more than 2–3 weeks.

Anamirta cocculus (Menispermaceae) Indian Berry, Cocculus

Description Large, woody climbing plant with alternate oval leaves and long hanging clusters of greenish flowers. Has male and female flowers on separate plants. Bears red-brown kidney-shaped fruit.

Habitat & Cultivation Indian berry is found in forests in Southeast Asia from India and Sri Lanka across to Indonesia.

Parts Used Leaves, fruit.

Constituents Indian berry contains picrotoxin (up to 5%) and alkaloids. Picrotoxin is a very powerful poison and nerve stimulant.

History & Folklore The fruit is used as a fish poison. Scattered in the water, it stupefies fish in the surrounding area, causing them to float to the surface.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Indian berry fruit is sold commercially as a remedy for parasites. The plant is so toxic that it is rarely taken internally. It is mainly applied externally to kill parasites such as lice. In Ayurvedic medicine, Indian berry fruit is classified as astringent, antifungal, and anthelmintic (de-worming), and is used for skin ulcers and fungal conditions such as ringworm. The herb is used in homeopathic medicine as a remedy for heart conditions.

⚠️ **Cautions** Indian berry is highly toxic. Do not take internally. Use externally only under professional supervision.

Ananas comosus (Bromeliaceae) Pineapple

Description Herbaceous perennial growing to 3 ft (1 m). Has a short, sturdy stem; spiny, lance-shaped leaves; and succulent reddish-yellow fruit.

Habitat & Cultivation Pineapple is native to South America. It is cultivated throughout the tropics for its fruit and, to a lesser extent, its leaf fiber.

Parts Used Fruit, leaves.

Constituents Pineapple fruit contains bromelain, a protein-splitting enzyme that aids digestion. It has significant levels of vitamins A and C.

Medicinal Actions & Uses The sour, unripe fruit improves digestion, increases appetite, and relieves dyspepsia. In Indian herbal medicine, it is thought to act as a uterine tonic. The ripe fruit cools and soothes, and is used to settle gas and reduce excessive gastric acid. Its significant fiber content makes it useful in relieving constipation. The juice of the ripe

fruit is both a digestive tonic and a diuretic. The leaves are considered to be useful in encouraging the onset of menstrual periods and easing painful ones.

Andrographis paniculata (Acanthaceae)

Andrographis, Green Chiretta, Kiratatiktah (Sanskrit)

Description Upright, branched annual, growing to 3 ft (90 cm), with lance-shaped leaves, spotted, pale brown or purple flowers, and long, thin seed capsules containing numerous yellow-brown seeds.

Habitat & Cultivation Andrographis grows throughout India, on plains, and as undergrowth in forests. It is commonly cultivated for medicinal use in northern India and China, and is also grown as a garden plant.

Parts Used Aerial parts.

Constituents Contains bitter diterpene lactones, diterpene glucosides, and flavonoids.

History & Folklore In Ayurveda, andrographis is used mainly for the liver, to treat infection, and for intestinal worms. In the past it has been used chiefly to treat malaria.

Medicinal Actions & Uses A classically bitter and tonic herb, andrographis exerts a wide range of protective effects on the body—mostly through its ability to stimulate the immune system, especially macrophages, and to protect the liver from damage, whether by infection or poisoning. Like most bitters, it will help to counter fever. In China, andrographis is used to treat a wide range of infections including bacillary dysentery and enteritis. It may be taken for chronic infection, and in any situation where the immune system is underperforming. Although it has no antiviral activity, andrographis can speed up recovery from the common cold.

Research In mostly Indian and Chinese research, the herb has been shown to stimulate the immune system, particularly helping to protect against poisoning (such as from snake bite).

The glucosides are strongly antioxidant, and extracts of the whole herb have demonstrated an effect similar to, or better than, silymarin (from *Silybum marianum*, p. 137) in supporting the function of the liver. Thai research published in 1991 indicated that 6 g per day of andrographis was as effective as acetaminophen in relieving fever and sore throat. The herb also has reported effectiveness against fertility.

Cautions Do not take during pregnancy. High doses may cause nausea and vomiting.



Pineapple contains an enzyme, bromelain, that acts as an aid to digestion.